

**Unit 1, Option D,  
Topic D5: Pursuing  
Life and Liberty:  
Equality in the  
USA, 1945-68**

The focus of this topic is on the struggle by black people in the USA for equal rights in the years between the end of the Second World War and the death of Martin Luther King in 1968. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of power and the influence of ideological challenge to power. The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the role of federal power and authority straddles bullet points 1 and 2. Comparisons might be invited on the philosophies and outlook of Martin Luther King and Black Power activists (bullet points 2 and 3).

The first bullet point relates to the situation throughout the USA in the decade after the Second World War. Students should understand something of the social, economic and political position of blacks in different parts of the USA and how, if at all, this position was changing. They should be aware of the impact of the Second World War, improving employment prospects, internal migration and the beginnings of reform. They should be aware of the work of the NAACP and understand the importance of the constitutional case of *Brown versus Board of Education* (1954-55).

The second bullet point relates to the high profile campaign associated with Martin Luther King in the late 1950s and the 1960s. Students should have an understanding of the forces opposed to equal rights and of the ways in which this opposition expressed itself. Students should have knowledge and understanding of the aims, methods and effectiveness of the civil rights movement. They should understand the salient features of the Civil Rights Acts of 1957, 1960, 1964, 1965 and 1968 in order to address the impact of the campaigns and the role of federal authority.